

Outlier vs the large IT integrators: Accenture, Capgemini and ot

When a company wants AI built rather than just recommended, the large IT integrators are often the first names that come to mind. Accenture and Capgemini are the best known in Europe, and firms like them run some of the largest technology programmes in the world.

If you lead a boutique firm of 50 to 100 people, the question is not whether these companies are capable. They clearly are. The question is whether their model fits a partnership that needs one or two well-built systems, not a multi-year transformation programme.

This article sets out the differences honestly. Think of the old Mac and PC adverts. The PC was the dependable workhorse of the enterprise, built to run thousands of desks the same way. The Mac was built for people who wanted something that simply worked for them. Both have their place. We are the Mac.

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Accenture reported revenue of US\$69.7 billion for fiscal year 2025 and describes itself as having approximately 779,000 people serving clients in more than 120 countries. In the same results, it reported generative AI new bookings of US\$5.9 billion for the year (Accenture, Q4 and full-year FY2025 results). In 2023, the firm announced a US\$3 billion investment over three years in its Data and AI practice, with a plan to double its AI talent to 80,000 people (Accenture newsroom).

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Capgemini reported 2025 revenue of €22,465 million and a year-end headcount of 423,400, operating in more than 50 countries. The company names the "agentification" of business processes as a strategic priority (Capgemini, full-year 2025 results). In October 2025 it completed the acquisition of WNS for a total cash consideration of US\$3.3 billion, a deal both companies framed around agentic AI and intelligent operations (WNS filing, SEC). Its management consultancy brand, Capgemini Invent, combines strategy, technology, data science and design (Capgemini Invent).

These are genuine strengths. The integrators have engineering depth, partnerships with every major cloud and software vendor, delivery centres that can run around the clock, and the discipline to deliver very large programmes. When a global insurer needs to migrate core systems, connect hundreds of applications and run AI on top of all of it, that capacity is hard to match.

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Integrators are built to deliver technology at volume. That shapes how they work, and it is not a flaw. It is what their clients need.

For a 50 to 100 person partnership, the fit can be awkward in a few places. These are general patterns in the industry and our own opinion, not claims about any specific project:

The Outlier w

The Outlier is a boutique AI and Transformation partner for firms of 50 to 100 people in advisory, mobility, HR, legal and recruitment, in the Netherlands and Belgium, with Europe and the UAE to follow. We build systems, but we start with people and process.

cess first, then the sy

Our founder, Fariza Sbaa, spent nearly two decades in HR, Global Mobility, Governance, Compliance and Transformation inside ING Bank, Heineken International and Media.Monks. Her background is in how organisations and people actually work, not just in the technology that supports them. That is why every engagement starts with the people doing the work.

wo-week scan before anything is b

The AI Friction Scan takes two weeks for a fixed €2,750. We interview three to five partners and five to eight people on the floor, map your three heaviest workflows and score every opportunity: quick win or structural system, hours saved, payback period. You get a one-page roadmap and know exactly what is worth building.

system, built in one qua

The AI Systems Sprint costs €12,500 and runs 8 to 12 weeks. We design and build one system that speeds up your core process: a proposal flow, client onboarding, an internal knowledge assistant or regulation monitoring. Want to start smaller? Sprint Light is €7,500 for six weeks and one subsystem.

ide the tools you already

We build in Microsoft 365, Google Workspace and your existing CRM. No new platform to buy, no vendor lock-in we benefit from. Your team gets two training sessions, documentation and a maintenance plan, so the system belongs to you.

sured in hours and e

Every sprint is measured before and after: hours saved per week, expressed in euros. If a system does not earn its place, we would rather know early than defend it later.

dership without a

Many boutique firms need someone to own the AI agenda over time, not just for one project. The Fractional AI Transformation Partner starts at €2,750 per month for two days a month at your management table, or €4,500 per month for four days including steering vendors and delivery.

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| | Large IT integrators | The Outlier |

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| Built for | Enterprise technology programmes | Boutique firms of 50 to 100 people |

| Starting point | Technology and platforms | People, process and friction |

| Who does the work | Architects plus delivery teams | The senior founder, hands on |

| First result | Depends on programme scope | Two-week AI Friction Scan |

| Typical build | Multi-system, multi-year programmes | One system in 8 to 12 weeks |

| Technology | Vendor alliances, new platforms | Your existing tools (M365, Google, CRM) |

| Pricing | Scoped per programme | Fixed, published prices |

n an integrator is the right ch

We want to be clear about this. A large integrator is the right choice if you need to replace or connect core systems across many entities. It is the right choice if you need 24/7 managed services and support across time zones. It is the right choice if you are building custom software that needs a large engineering team, or if your AI work depends on a deep integration with an enterprise platform where the integrator is a certified partner.

If that is your situation, their scale is an asset, not overhead.

n The Outlier is the better

The Outlier is the better fit when your firm is too small for its own AI team and too big to keep running on goodwill and spreadsheets. When you need someone to find where time leaks away before anyone writes a line of code. When you want one system that your people actually use, built in the tools they already open every morning, at a price you know in advance.

The enterprise workhorse runs a thousand desks. We are the Mac for the partnership that wants its experts to scale.

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Take the free assessment at /start to see where your firm stands today. If a scan makes sense, the AI Friction Scan gives you a roadmap with payback figures in two weeks, for a fixed €2,750. If it does not, we will say so.

Company names are trademarks of their respective owners. This comparison reflects publicly available information as of October 2026.